between the IMF and the Requesting Party that involves a commitment of the IMF to provide financing to the Requesting Party based on conditionality, and the compliance of the Requesting Party with the terms and conditions of the arrangement' (VI BRICS Summit 2014b). The neoliberal BRICS bureaucrats who laboured over that stilted language – and over the (self-obfuscating) name of the CRA – may or may not have a sense of how close global finance is to another meltdown, in part because of relentless IMF austerity conditionality. But it does reveal their intrinsic commitment to 'sound banking' mentality, by limiting their own liabilities to each other. Current quotas are in the range of $18–20 billion for the four larger BRICS and $10 billion for South Africa (though the latter will only contribute $5 billion, and China $41 billion).

Will it matter? According to São Paolo-based geopolitical analyst Oliver Stuenkel (2013), 'arrangements similar to the BRICS CRA already exist and have not undermined the IMF. The BRICS' CRA is closely modelled on the Chiang Mai Initiative signed between the Association of Southeastern Asian Nations countries as well as China, Japan and South Korea in May 2000.' The initiative is useless, Stuenkel observes, for no one has borrowed from it since. Likewise, he argues, 'The CRA is fully embedded in the IMF system!' What might that mean in future? The last BRICS country default managed by Washington was when Boris Yeltsin's Russia – with US$150 billion in foreign debt – required a US$23 billion emergency loan in 1998. Fifteen years later, four of the five BRICS suffered currency crashes when the US Federal Reserve announced monetary policy changes, and with higher interest rates, hot money flooded back to New York. An emergency bailout may soon be necessary in South Africa, where foreign indebtedness has risen to more than US$140 billion, up from US$25 billion in 1994, when Nelson Mandela's ANC inherited apartheid debt and, tragically, agreed to repay. Measured in terms of GDP, foreign debt is over 40% and even the neoliberal South African Reserve Bank (2014) warns that we are fast approaching 'the high of 41% registered at the time of the debt standstill in 1985'. That crisis and an accompanying US$13 billion default split the white ruling class, compelling English-speaking big business representatives to visit Zambia to meet the exiled liberation movement (Bond 2014b). Less than nine years later, capital had ditched the racist Afrikaner regime, in favour of bedding down with the ANC in what Mandela's key military strategist Ronnie Kasrils (2013) termed the 'Faustian pact'.

South African Finance Minister Nhlanhla Nene predicted that the first NDB borrowers would be African, to 'complement the efforts of existing international financial institutions' (Creamer 2014). But since Nene's own Development Bank